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Schrödinger's Woman: Essentialism and Modern Feminism

For many, life is a process of fitting experiences into boxes. These boxes are compartmentalized and eventually become ideas, then beliefs. Educators and public figures can change these beliefs to an extent, yet these foundational experiences of thought can define the way individuals approach the world. In the context of gender studies, second and third-wave feminists frequently debated the value of “gender essentialism,” or a unifying definition of “woman.” Simone de Beauvoir is frequently cited: “One is not born, but becomes a woman.” This quote began the modern distinction between sex and gender. Beauvoir and like-minded feminists vehemently criticized the idea of gender essentialism; instead, they broadly advocated for “gender performativity.” Gender performativity refers to the unconscious performance of a “gender identity.” This theory centered on personal agency and identity regarding gender, which broadly undermined the unifying efforts of essentialists. If one cannot be born a woman, then perhaps “gender realism” is as fictitious as “race realism.” The “woman question” has undeniably shaped modern feminist discourse; to understand the current dissonance between political action and feminist thought, it is essential to characterize this debate.

‘Essentialists’ and ‘Anti-essentialists’ are often placed in complete opposition. This dichotomy, however, is unsatisfactory. These two branches alone contain many variations of their own ideology – not to mention the anti-anti essentialists who fall in a more moderate position.

For analytical simplicity, these two will be referred to by their broader titles and qualified when necessary.

First-wave feminists spearheaded essentialism. Advocates like Elizabeth Cady Stanton asserted that there were inherent ties between women and care work. While it is harmful to generalize the movement, the general rhetoric of first-wave feminists took the solidity of “woman” for granted. This, rather than any formal definition, is the introduction of essentialist thought; asserting “woman” as a universal term instituted a foundational problem that would later be conflated with politics. As an example, Stanton is quoted saying: “as a woman, an equal factor in civilization, her rights and duties are still the same – individual happiness and development”(Stanton 1). Indeed, her sentiment supports feminist ends, yet takes the universality of “woman” for granted. The first-wave feminists are often criticized for this, though it remains important to reconcile these differences with the historical context. Fighting for equal representation required a unifying factor; no progress could be made toward any future provisional answers to “what is a woman” without it. Her speeches advocated for equal access to education and general recognition by society as a contribution rather than a drain. Material conditions, then, defined this wave of thought and essentially inscribed a time bomb into a “declaration of independence for women.” Future generations would have to deal with this faulty foundation and would hopefully have the conditions to foster that level of thinking.

Second-wave feminism was defined by the pursuit of this answer. Beauvoir, often credited as the pioneer of second-wave feminism, claimed that no satisfactory definition could ever exist: “the reason why otherness in this case seems to be an absolute is in part that it lacks the contingent or incidental nature of historical facts”(Beauvoir 18). While a universally applicable definition would help to organize political movements, according to Beauvoir, women

are a uniquely oppressed group: “But women are not a minority, like the American Negroes or the Jews; there are as many women as men on Earth”(Beauvoir 17). She described the frequent inequality of numbers that create systemic oppression, yet women have always had equality in numbers. A mere majority is neither sufficient nor necessary in creating systems of oppression. Wealth inequality disproportionately harms the proletariat, or working class; the working class, by definition, make up the majority of a population in capitalist systems. She qualifies, however: “Proletarians have not always existed, whereas there have always been women”(Beauvoir 18). Her introduction fails to introduce any common variable for women to organize around, which follows her argument that it cannot exist. Despite mentioning these relationships in reference to political and social conflicts, she avoids directly conflating the political and the social; considering the political implications of “normative” legislation, this distinction is key.

Judith Butler and other third-wave feminists were essential in defining “performative gender”; her argument, however, fails to avoid the conflation. She initially proposes that gender is fluid, or rather: “In an important sense, gender is not traceable to a definable origin because it is itself an originating activity incessantly taking place”(Butler 507). Any attempt to universally define a subjective experience will inadvertently exclude some version of the same concept. Assuming that she is correct and that gender is fluid, it is a normative concept, not a positive one. Since normative concepts are defined by subjective experience and beliefs, essentialist rhetoric is destined to exclude; exclusion, notably, is antithetical to essentialist ends. Responding to Beauvoir, Butler labels gender as a “contemporary way of organizing past and future cultural norms”(Butler 507). In doing so, she attaches gender to politics. While her understanding of gender is foundational to modern feminist literature, Butler oversteps the bounds of philosophical thought, moving gender into politics.

Butler and Beauvoir have especially effective arguments against essentialism. Despite the quality of their arguments, however, their approach fails at a foundational level. Beauvoir herself states: “The biological and social sciences no longer admit the existence of unchangeably fixed entities that determine given characteristics, such as those ascribed to woman, the Jew, or the Negro. Science regards any characteristic as a reaction dependent in part upon a situation”(Beauvoir 13). She correctly identifies the fallacious origins of any racial or gender realist arguments but fails to apply them to her own circumstance. Beauvoir, unlike Butler, had fewer opportunities to access information and lived in a less diverse country – France. Due to these circumstances, it followed that her perspective on racism would be more abstract. Butler, however, recognizes her argument and decides to replatform an argument with no factual basis. Attempting to combat fallacies with logic inevitably fails in the long run, as “positive” arguments can only be so effective against “normative” beliefs. In conflating gender and status, Butler finds the correct conclusion and the wrong solution. Even considering the importance of “power” in her argument, she could have avoided enshrining identity itself into political thought by emphasizing universality; her argument requires the analysis of identity and power, though specifically including identity in terms of policy is a noticeable contradiction. One can only pursue a genderless society through abandonment of terms, rather than the enshrinement of fluidity as a staple in political thought.

In the U.S., the concept of “whiteness” permeates discussions of privilege. Despite its prevalence, the notion of what whiteness means changes quite often. In the early twentieth century, Irish, Italian, and Jewish Americans all had “minority” status. Over time, however, due to the adoption of ideals that fit these groups into an umbrella “in-group,” they gained social “whiteness.”¹ Race and gender parallel each other in this fluidity. If successful civil rights efforts

¹ Weidner, Genevieve. “The Power of Perception.”

surpassed rigid categories, modern feminists can as well. Accordingly, a more accurate assessment of gender fluidity would parallel its relative relationship in oppressive structures. Political efforts which resulted in long-term change for minority groups heavily rely on neutral, universal, and humanist language. This is essential in understanding why the “essentialist” question is one that ought only to exist in academia and philosophy. There need not be some unifying definition, for political efforts that pursue feminist ends aim for the dismantling of systemic oppression, which need not be gendered. These efforts could take many forms, but the legislation required for such a class upheaval would have to be gender-neutral.

Tying identities to politics inevitably leads to harmful conflations. The Jewish population in the United States, at the time of writing, is currently experiencing a return to minority status due to this same pattern of conflation². During the 20th century, secular Zionist leaders conflated Judaism and the apartheid state of Israel³. In a modern context, Jewish populations are now blamed for Zionist atrocities⁴. This outcome is by design. As Audre Lorde put it: “The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house”(Lorde). Beauvoir and Butler are correct in their assessments of gender but failed to avoid using the language of their oppressors. Free speech and thought are inherently limited by language, just as one cannot explain color to a person who cannot see. Arguing for gender performance and identity as a reliable substitute for essentialism is a political trap that these two cannot escape. Furthermore, the usage of normative language such as “identity” to solve the primarily political goals of essentialists labels gender fluidity as a form of class-consciousness, which is inherently contradictory. The coherent and consistent goals

² Beinart, Peter. “Debunking the Myth That Anti-Zionism Is Antisemitic | Peter Beinart.” *The Guardian*, Guardian News and Media, 7 Mar. 2019

³ Friedman, George. “Israel and the Emerging Crisis of the Secular and the Religious.”

⁴ JVP. “On Antisemitism, Anti-Zionism and Dangerous Conflations.” *JVP*, 12 May 2025,

of language – whether political or academic – cannot be met without first addressing the quantum superposition of womanhood.

Genderless legislation may seem impossible; this, however, is another symptom of gendered language. In countries with governments that aim to protect all constituents – which the United States claims to be – any gendered language is exclusionary. Thus, in a political context, the “woman” question is inherently meaningless; despite this, it still remains important for academia and gender studies. Identity is a human experience, so discovering how far it can reach is an inherent human goal. Further, the pursuit of knowledge is the entire point of academia, which this question satisfies.

If Beauvoir is correct in her claim that, “humanity is male and man defines woman not in herself but as relative to him”(Beauvoir 15), then the goal of feminists should be dismantling the oppressive capacity to “other.” In responding to first-wave feminists, second, third, and fourth-wave feminists used normative speech to address positive ends. These two groups essentially speak a different language. Accordingly, the discord that follows trans-inclusionary debate is a symptom of its futility. There is undoubtedly patriarchal oppression that continues to oppress women, and political efforts ought to continue against such structures. What must change, however, is the modern insistence of a dyadic conflict between essentialists and anti-essentialists. This debate arose from an unfortunate conflation, due to material conditions, between political goals and academia; it is essential that modern feminists shift the subject, recognizing this debate as a spectrum between the political and philosophical is the next step towards linguistic freedom.

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